



RAIN MEN

PRIESTS PERFORM the Varuna Yajna, immersing themselves in water for over four hours to invoke the rain gods in Mumbai. Drought has been declared in 161 of 625 districts in the country following failed monsoons.

AHMEDABAD | Centre Court

The Jaswant Singh saga is now turning into a legal cause. He has already moved the Supreme Court challenging the ban imposed by the Narendra Modi Government on his controversial book in Gujarat on technical grounds. But the judicial jousting on the issue began last week when two social activists of Ahmedabad, Prakash Shah and Manishi Jani, challenged the ban in the Gujarat High Court citing violation of fundamental rights to freedom of expression and inquiry, thus throwing the gauntlet back at Modi. Neither are Singh sympathisers and their act is based solely on principle. The initial response from the bench headed by Gujarat Chief Justice K.S. Radhakrishnan was revealing. He remarked: "The notification banning the book must show application of mind. There are a mere few words here and there." In the state where Sardar Patel is worshipped as god and Modi has popular support, the high court throwing out the ban would mean a moral victory of sorts. *by Uday Mahurkar*

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